



Subarnarekha The Golden Line

Director: Ritwik Ghatak

Production Company: J.J. Films Corporation

Screenplay: Ritwik Ghatak

Story: Ritwik Ghatak, Radheshyam Jhunjhunwala

Director of Photography:

Dilip Ranjan Mukhopadhyay

Editor: Ramesh Joshi

Music: Ustad Bahadur Khan

Sound: Satyen Chatterjee

Cast:

Abhi Bhattacharya (*Ishwar*)

Madhabi Mukherjee (*Sita*)

Satindra Bhattacharya (*Abhiram*)

Bijon Bhattacharya (*Haraprasad*)

Sriman Tarun (*young Abhiram*)

Gita De (*Kausalya, Abhiram's mother*)

Jahar Roy (*Mukherjee*)

Abanish Bandyopadhyay (*Hari Babu*)

India 1965

132 mins

Digital 4K (restoration)

The restoration of *Subarnarekha* was made possible by the National Film Development Corporation of India and the National Film Archive of India.

The screening on Sun 28 Jun will include a pre-recorded intro

Become a BFI Member

Enjoy a great package of film benefits including priority booking at BFI Southbank and BFI Festivals. Join today at bfi.org.uk/join

Sight and Sound

Never miss an issue with **Sight and Sound**, the BFI's internationally renowned film magazine. Subscribe from just £25*

* Price based on a 6-month print subscription (UK only). More info:

sightandsoundsubs.bfi.org.uk/subscribe



BFI Player

We are always open online on BFI Player where you can watch the best new, cult & classic cinema on demand. Showcasing hand-picked landmark British and independent titles, films are available to watch in three distinct ways: Subscription, Rentals & Free to view.

See something different today on player.bfi.org.uk

Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

Subarnarekha

A refugee family resettles near an industrial landscape by a river, hoping to rebuild their lives after Partition. Years of struggle, separation and social prejudice lead to the collapse of those hopes. Epic in feeling, yet intimate in the pain it conveys, Ghatak's film fuses melodrama, myth and politics into a tragic vision of a new nation scarred by the Partition.

bfi.org.uk

4 November 2025 marked Ritwik Ghatak's 100th birthday. That is, it would have if he hadn't passed away back in 1976 at the age of just 50 (6 February was the 50th anniversary of his death). The brilliant Bengali director is a peripheral figure for most western cinephiles, though they may well be aware of his sublime *The Cloud-Capped Star* (1960), thanks to its inclusion in the Criterion Collection, and possibly *A River Called Titas* (1973), restored by Martin Scorsese's World Cinema Project. In India itself, Ghatak is celebrated as one of the trio of great 20th-century filmmakers, alongside Satyajit Ray and Mrinal Sen, and *Subarnarekha* (filmed in 1962 but released three years later) is recognised as a classic.

I encountered *Subarnarekha* in the bowels of the BFI's Stephen Street office in London, a few floors below the *Sight and Sound* office. This was in 1997, and I had been invited to write an article for *Time Out* about a Ghatak season at the National Film Theatre (as it then was), timed to mark the 50th anniversary of India's independence and concomitant partition from Pakistan, a pivotal episode in Ghatak's life and work. I really didn't know anything about Ghatak going into the screening room, but when I came out 132 minutes later I was shaken and inspired. Indeed, I've been banging the drum for this movie ever since (and twice voted for it in this magazine's Greatest Films poll).

Subarnarekha is the name of a river in West Bengal, known for its trace deposits of gold. This river winds its metaphorical way through the film, a symbol of hope, and/or false hope (fool's gold). It is the story of Ishwar, a Hindu teacher displaced from the north by Partition and caught up in a refugee colony in 1948 with his much younger sister, Sita. In the film's opening scenes, he adopts an orphaned lower caste boy of Sita's age, Abhi, when the child's mother is snatched off the street by armed thugs. Later, a chance encounter with an old college friend yields a job offer in a provincial factory a position that will allow Ishwar to escape the camp and secure a future for Sita and Abhi, even if it means putting his family above the needs of his community. 'The British have a word for people like you,' his idealistic fellow teacher Haraprasad reprimands him: 'Deserter.'

A few years later, Ishwar's choice seems to have paid off. He's to be promoted to manager. Sita has grown into a lovely young woman. Abhi is about to graduate and Ishwar plans to send him to Germany to study engineering. But the younger man aspires to become a novelist, and worse, he and Sita are in love. When his employer becomes aware of Abhi's caste, Ishwar is persuaded to send him back to Calcutta to make his own way in the world, and to arrange for Sita to be married off. It's a complete betrayal of principles that sets up the film's tragic third act.

Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

The Citizen Nagarik

Mon 1 Jun 20:35; Fri 26 Jun 18:05 (+ intro by Ashvin Devasundaram, Queen Mary University of London)

Ritwik Ghatak Season Introduction:

A River Called Ritwik

Tue 2 Jun 18:15

The Pathetic Fallacy Ajantrik

Tue 2 Jun 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Sun 21 Jun 18:30

Incomplete Works

Wed 3 Jun 17:50 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Sat 20 Jun 18:10

Reason, Debate and a Story

Jukti Takko Aar Gappo

Wed 3 Jun 20:25 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Tue 30 Jun 20:40

The Traveller Musafir

Sat 6 Jun 20:10; Sun 14 Jun 18:00

Shorts and Documentaries

Sun 7 Jun 12:30; Mon 22 Jun 18:30

The Uprooted Chinnamul

Mon 8 Jun 20:35; Sat 20 Jun 12:15

Subarnarekha The Golden Line

Wed 10 Jun 20:25; Sun 28 Jun 12:00
(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Cloud-Capped Star Meghe Dhaka Tara

Thu 11 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Manishita Dass, author of *BFI Film Classic: The Cloud-Capped Star*); Sat 27 Jun 14:40

A River Called Titas Titash Ekti Nadir Naam

Sat 13 Jun 14:20 (+ intro by Tanjil Rashid, Culture Editor at the *New Statesman*); Sun 28 Jun 14:50

E-Flat Komol Gandhar

Sat 13 Jun 20:20; Sat 27 Jun 17:30
(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Runaway Bari Theke Paliye

Wed 17 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Agni Lahiri, film protagonist's son and producer's grandson); Sat 27 Jun 12:10

The Diamond Butterfly Heerer Prajapati

Sun 21 Jun 15:15; Sun 28 Jun 18:15

Ghatak described his conception of cinema as a weapon to raise public consciousness, and this is a more overtly political film than *The Cloud-Capped Star*. The first words we hear are 'Long live the Motherland' as the Indian flag is raised over a new school in the refugee colony, but it's clear that Ghatak sympathises with Haraprasad's sense that the country was betrayed from its inception. With news of the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi, gunshots break over the diegetic soundtrack, the first salvo in the director's Brechtian experiments with sound.

An iconoclast, Ghatak infuses a predominantly naturalistic but heavily freighted *mise en scène* with striking compositions, fluid camera movement and cutting that seems designed to keep us asking questions. Despite the poverty of its settings (the arid banks of the shallow river; an abandoned British air force base; a slum apartment), the movie often feels very modern in its uninhibited application of lessons from Welles, Eisenstein and the *nouvelle vague*. Equally, Ghatak's commitment to idealists and underdogs – exiles, refugees, orphans, women, artists, activists – still rings loud and clear 60 years later.

Less modern, perhaps, is the filmmaker's sternly Marxist moralism. Ghatak had a clear sense of where the world was heading: 'Calcutta is full of fun now,' Haraprasad tells Ishwar towards the end, when both men have lost all hope. 'Such horrible fun! You will be stunned to see how people let themselves go with the current. The way of the herd is Truth. Indulgence is the way to liberation. Letting oneself be swept away with the current. Such intoxication! You lose everything and still want more.'

It's perhaps not too much to hope for that this incendiary and inspiring piece of filmmaking should merit wider recognition in the west. A film of this power and poetry must surely prevail. At least this is an illusion we can cling to, like that utopian golden river, glinting in the distance.

Tom Charity, *Sight and Sound*, March 2026

In partnership with

NFDC
cinemas of india

ntai
national film
archive of india

On the birth centenary of Ritwik Ghatak, NFDC-NFAI carried out unprecedented digital preservation of his entire filmography including feature length films, numerous shorts, documentaries and unfinished works, all under the National Film Heritage Mission. The eight features have been restored in 4K from various film elements preserved by NFDC-NFAI and West Bengal State Film Archive, with colour grading supervised by renowned Indian cinematographer Avik Mukhopadhyay.

Programme notes and credits compiled by Sight and Sound and the BFI Documentation Unit

Notes may be edited or abridged | Browse online at theb.fi/programme-notes

Questions/comments? Email prognotes@bfi.org.uk